encourages teams to externalize decision logic—regardless of form—and evaluate it dynamically at runtime. Whether policies are expressed as structured data or executable code, they enable flexible, dynamic, and timely authorization decisions that adapt to changing context. This shift brings consistency to access decisions, makes policies easier to reason about, and supports better governance as systems grow. PBAC offers a common architecture for modern, adaptable authorization.

ACME Corp's path to mature authorization reflected the broader evolution of the identity industry. Early on, developers used simple Access Control Lists (ACLs) to specify who could access which resources—perfectly adequate when the team was small and access needs were predictable. As the company expanded, the need for a structured approach grew. Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) helped align permissions with job functions, providing the identity team with a scalable approach to handle onboarding, offboarding, and audits.

But growth introduced complexity. The Customer Collaboration platform, where access depended on relationships between employees and customers, pushed ACME toward Relationship-Based Access Control (ReBAC). Meanwhile, internal systems—like production deployment tools and HR applications—required fine-grained, context-aware policies. Attribute-Based Access Control (ABAC) allowed ACME to enforce rules based on factors such as time of day, device posture, and clearance level. Each model added flexibility and nuance, solving problems the previous one couldn't.

Table 6.7 summarizes how each model approaches authorization.